By Narayan Krishnamurthy

Old-time residents of Malleswaram will remind you of many historical events associated with the locality. It has pockets where generations have continued to reside and have long-standing bonds. Like many other homes here, the Shastri household has four generations living in an independent house, which has stood here for over half a century. Over time, the house has witnessed its share of modifications to meet the changing needs of the family as well as to address the issues of modernity. "My father inherited this house from his father and the house has a history that dates back to over a hundred years," beams a proud 56-year-old Seshadri Shastri.

The two-storey house is home to Seshadri and his wife, his octogenarian parents, his mother-in-law who will be soon turning 80, his son and daughter-in-law and the youngest in the household, his two-year-old granddaughter. He has another son, who is completing his master's. Besides the eight family members, the house has a full-time help and a other staff who trickle in and out to help them manage their needs. "I am up most days by 5 am to get my shot of coffee and fight any residual sleep," says Rama, Seshadri's wife. The claimants for coffee at that hour include her husband and her mother, who moved in with them a year ago after her father's demise.

Up north in Noida, "it's overwhelming trying to manage it all," for 42-year-old Rashi Arora, who is a caregiver for her parents as well as her in-laws, besides having her house to look after with one school- and one college-going daughter and businessman husband. "I am maintaining two households, as my parents refused to move in with me, even though space wasn't a constraint," she adds. She is lucky that her parents agreed to move into an apartment close to hers, which helps reduce her commute in case of any emergencies that crop up with them.

Welcome to the world of the Sandwich Generation (see *Who is the Sandwich*

WHO IS THE SANDWICH GENERATION?

Unlike Gen X or millennials or Gen Z, the Sandwich Generation is not defined by the decade they are born in. They are just a generation caught between two other generations, the preceding one, as well as the upcoming one. They are the ones shouldering the financial responsibility, with the parents having retired, and the children still in school. The sets of needs, too, are contrasting. While healthcare expenses form the bulk of the elderly generation's needs, it's school and college fees that have to be accounted for in the case of one's children. In addition, there are one's own lifestyle expenses, such as EMIs on housing loans, bills to pay, the salaries of household help, taking an occasional holiday, or saving for one's retirement.

Taking care of their financial needs apart, the Sandwich Generation often has to juggle their jobs and the responsibilities of running the household—from doing chores around the house to grocery shopping to taking care of the elderly to minding young children. There is also the additional stress of rising inflation and an increasingly insecure work environment, like the one that was seen during the Covid-19 pandemic, when thousands of Indians were laid off, or their salaries curtailed.

THE COMPLEXITY INVOLVED

WHO ARE THEY?	CHALLENGES	SOLUTIONS
Adults in the 40 to 60-year age group	Rising financial pressure from two sets of dependants	Talk about your financial situations
They have to care for their aging parents/ in-laws as well as their growing children simultaneously	Balancing full-time jobs/business and caring for the family	Be adequately insured—health for all family members and your life
	Delayed personal financial goals	Save towards your retirement
	Mental and financial pressure	Seek help where needed

Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE